10. Decline and Fall …

‘You, or your team, will reveal themselves.’

Andy Flower’s summary of the challenge of Test cricket, articulated in clipped tones that disguised his sensitivity, stayed with me throughout my England captaincy. He was right; the highest form of the game exposes who you are, individually and collectively. It takes no prisoners. It spins you round and spits you out.

It is diametrically opposed to the one-day game, where the mathematics of the occasion dictate your approach. Test cricket offers greater opportunity to impose yourself on the situation, because of its length and intricacy. It doesn’t tell you what to do, through force of circumstance. To survive, you must find a way that works for you.

It can suck the life out of you. Not many batsmen who go straight back to county cricket after being found wanting bounce back immediately. They endure what is almost a period of mourning; it takes time to rediscover the mental fortitude required if they are to regroup. On the way up, or the way down, your promise or failure is emphasized by the TV news ticker, a snapshot that sums up your performance in a few words or numbers.

It is a dive into very deep, extremely cold and invariably murky water. What is talent? Can it be defined only by its reproduction on a regular basis? Skills are nothing without application, and delivery of results. Certain players have obvious attributes – the ability to swing the ball both ways or to bat with conviction and imagination – but they lack that intangible force to fulfil themselves.